

INVENTORY · STACK · STRUCTURE

principles

Declared statements — short stated principles, each with a one-line justification.

How we make calls when the spec is silent.

Default to the cheaper-to-reverse choice. Reversible decisions don't need a meeting; only the irreversible ones do.

Name the actor, never the system. "The PM decides" lands; "the process decides" hides who is accountable.

Write the bet down next to the choice. A decision recorded without its predicted outcome can't be learned from later.

Disagree in the room, commit outside it. Dissent is cheap before the call and expensive after.

Optimise for the reader who wasn't there. If the log needs a translator, it isn't a log.

How we resolve conflicts — top wins.

- 01 Default to the choice that is cheaper to reverse.

- 02 Name the actor, never the system.

- 03 Write the bet on the same slide as the choice.

- 04 Let form follow function.

- 05 Keep one main idea per slide.

How we make calls when the spec is silent.

- A** Default to the choice that is cheaper to reverse.

- B** Name the actor, never the system.

- C** Write the bet on the same slide as the choice.

- D** Let form follow function.

- E** Keep one main idea per slide.

The editorial canon.

I Plain words beat clever ones.

II One claim per sentence.

III Show the number, then the verdict.

IV Cut the adverb, keep the verb.

V End on the decision, not the summary.

What we optimise for, in no particular order.

- Reversibility over consensus — make the cheap-to-undo call now.

- Clarity over completeness — one true thing beats five hedged ones.

- Ownership over process — processes don't get paged.

- Evidence over instinct — write the prediction down so it can be scored.

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When NOT to reach for principles.

Aspirations, not principles. "Be empathetic" is a value, not a principle. Principles are decision rules — they say what to do when two options conflict. Reach for content if it's a values statement.

Long per-principle prose. Each justification is one sentence. If a principle needs a paragraph of context, give it its own slide and let principles act as the index.

Hedged statements. "We try to default to X" reads as a wish. Drop the hedge — principles are declared, not negotiated. "Default to X" lands harder.

See also.

RELATED COMPONENTS

- `actors` — rules attach to named owners, not shared tenets
- `tldr` — single-line takeaways without justification body
- `list` — items are short bullets without title + body shape
- `cards-stack` — each principle needs two sentences of body